

Media Representations of Health Research:

Health Literacy: degree to which individuals have capacity to obtain, process, understand health information and services needed to make appropriate decisions

News Literacy: acquisition of 21st century critical thinking skills for analyzing/judging reliability of news and information, differentiating among facts, opinions, and assertions in the media we consume/create/distribute

The digital age poses 4 challenges for civil society:

1. Overwhelming amount of daily information makes it difficult to sort out reliable vs fabricated information
2. New technologies to create/widely share information make it easier for misinformation that appears to be from an authoritative source to spread
3. Conflict between speed and accuracy has escalated (we want information asap, but accelerating distribution of it in the Digital Era has increased chances that information will be wrong)
4. Internet and Social Media make it easier to select only information that supports preexisting beliefs, reinforcing rather than challenging them (confirmation bias)

Fake vs Real News:

- Fake: news that is factually incorrect information published on subject whose main objective is to mislead consumer in believing what is being conveyed for meeting his/her own interest (may be commercial, political, etc)
- Real: contains authentic real byline of a genuine journalist dedicated to the truth. Includes multiple primary sources, validating the sources and analysis when discussing a contentious claim

7 Types of Mis/disinformation:

1. Satire/parody: no intention to cause harm, but has potential to fool
2. Misleading content: misleading use of info to frame an issue/individual
3. Imposter content: when genuine sources are impersonated
4. Fabricated content: new content is 100% false, designed to deceive/do harm
5. False connection: headlines/visuals/captions don't support the content
6. False content: genuine content is shared with false contextual information
7. Manipulated content: when genuine information/imagery is manipulated to deceive

Fake News:

- Disinformation: deliberate creation and sharing of information known to be false
- Misinformation: inadvertent sharing of false information

these two types of content (sometimes combined mistakenly into fake news) are created and disseminated by state and private actors, often using bots

- Fake news: false stories that seem to be news, spread on Internet/other media, usually created to influence political views or as joke

How to spot fake news:

1. Fact-checking sites (ex. Politifact, Factcheck.org, Truth be Told, etc)
2. RADAR (Rationale, Authority, Date, Accuracy, Relevance)
3. CRAAP Test (Currency, Relevance, Authority, Accuracy, Purpose)

Characteristics of Academic Writing:

1. Objectivity:

- writing must not be based on personal opinion, needs to have strong/clear links to research-based evidence and established concepts.
- You are contributing to an academic debate, therefore your opinions must be expressed objectively.
- Thoughts, ideas, insights based upon analysis from evidence (references) rather than personal feelings/biases.

2. Classifying and Listing:

- Group and name things on basis of something that they have in common
- Understand certain qualities and fears which they share
- Understand differences between things

3. Formality and Precision:

- Standard written form of English, rather than our daily spoken language
- More varied vocab and more formal grammar
- No slang, colloquialism, vague or unclear words
- Define terms and concepts

4. Describing Quantities:

- Many combos of prepositions and pronouns
- Many terms of approximation (nearly, approximately, over half, less than, just over)

5. Hedging:

- Avoid expressing absolute certainty, making over-generalizations or sweeping statements where a small number of exceptions might exist
- In research papers, discussion sections are rich in hedging devices (writers offer explanations for findings)

6. Explaining Causality:

- Understanding, suggesting solutions to problems
- Solutions cannot be suggested unless the problem is fully analysed, this involves a thorough understanding of the causes

Where are you getting your information?

- Newspapers, blogs, websites, magazines containing news, written by reports who may/may not be experts in field of the article
- Online/print articles written by academics and/or pros who are 'experts', but may have skewed ideas
- Peer-reviewed journals with articles written by experts, reviewed by several other experts in field to ensure article quality prior to publishing
- Grey literature includes documents produced by government, NGOs, academics of sufficient quality to be collected/preserved by library and institutional repositories (not controlled by commercial publishers)

Being a critical consumer of information:

- Be critical of sources: question what you read, don't agree with it just because its published
- Look for reason why we shouldn't accept something as correct/true
- Identify problems with a writer's argument/methods or refer to other people's criticisms of these
- Avoid the echo chamber effect